



Time after time, both unleashed haymakers. They had already hammered seven forehands each over 100 mph! Serving at 4-5 in the fourth set, Alcaraz self-destructed with backhand and forehand errors and a double fault. Suddenly, he was down Triple Championship Point!

He escaped the first with a strong, deep forehand cross-court that forced a Sinner forehand error. He saved the second when Sinner recklessly overhit a backhand service return past the baseline. And he got lucky on the third when Sinner underhit a mid-court forehand that he should have belted and netted the next forehand. At 40-all, Alcaraz hit

an ace and a forehand winner on the dead run to hold serve. Disaster averted!

Riding that momentum and increasingly louder cries of "Carlos! Carlos!" the Spaniard broke for 5-all. "This is going to be a tall order for Sinner now, even though he's ahead," said McEnroe. That order became even taller when Alcaraz took the fourth-set tiebreak 7-3 on a forehand approach winner. McEnroe called the great escape "definitely a Houdini act."

Alcaraz served for the match at 5-4 in the fifth. This time it was Sinner who escaped from the jaws of defeat. He sprinted forward and scraped up

a superb Alcaraz drop shot to conjure an even better drop shot that landed inches from the net. That made the score 15-40. The Italian converted the critical break point with a powerful backhand service return that forced a forehand error.

Fittingly, two games later, a 10-point Match Tiebreak would decide this epic match. Nobody is better than Alcaraz when he plays his A+ game. Going into lockdown mode and striking the ball better than ever, Alcaraz streaked to a 7-0 lead. The most spectacular and unusual shot came when Sinner struck a solid backhand approach down the line. Anticipating it and displaying the